Safer Opioid Prescribing for Pain Management: Conversation Starters

This resource provides conversation starters designed to facilitate discussions between health care providers and patients regarding the safer prescribing and use of opioids. Aligned with the CDC Clinical Practice Guideline for Prescribing Opioids for Pain — United States, 2022, these conversation starters emphasize the importance of patient safety at every step of the pain management process. The 2022 CDC Guideline excludes pain management related to sickle cell disease, cancer-related pain treatment, palliative care, and end-of-life care, and clarifies that cancer-related pain treatment applies to cancer survivors. The information provided in this document is intended for educational and informational purposes only and is not a substitute for professional medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment.

Topic	Patient Conversation Starters
Discussing Opioid Treatment and Pain Management	**To assess previous treatments and ensure the patient is informed about nonopioid options** • "Before we consider opioids, can we review the other methods you've tried to manage your pain and how they've worked for you?" • "Can we discuss the benefits and risks of opioid therapy in detail to ensure you feel informed?" • "Starting with nonopioid treatments can often be effective and safer. Would you be open to exploring these options first?" • "Can you describe a typical day and how pain affects your activities?" • "What are your primary concerns about starting opioid therapy?" • "Have you had any past experiences with opioids? If so, how did they affect you?"
Discussing Dosages and Monitoring	**To explain the rationale for starting with the lowest dose and importance of follow-ups** • "To minimize risks, we will begin with the lowest effective dose of an immediate-release opioid. How do you feel about starting with this approach?" • "Using immediate-release opioids allows us to better control your dosage. Do you have any concerns about this approach?" • "It's important to balance effective pain relief while minimizing risk, including understanding any unique risks related to your current medications. How comfortable are you with frequent check-ins to monitor your progress?"
Ensuring Safe Opioid Storage and Disposal	**To emphasize the importance of secure storage and proper disposal of medications** • "It's crucial to store your medications securely to prevent misuse or accidental ingestion. Do you have a lockable cabinet or safe at home?" • "Let's discuss the importance of keeping your medication out of reach of children. Where do you plan to store your medication?" • "Proper disposal of unused medication is crucial for safety. Are you familiar with medication disposal options?" • "Have you ever stored medications at home before? What steps did you take to ensure they were secure?"
Discussing Risks and Mitigating Harm	**To discuss potential risks, address concerns, and ensure the patient understands how to mitigate harm** • "Given your medical history, we need to be particularly careful with opioid use. Do you have any concerns that you think we should discuss?" • "It's important to discuss the potential for addiction and other risks associated with opioids. Are you comfortable talking about these concerns? • "I strongly recommend having naloxone on hand as a precaution. It's a medication that can reverse an overdose. Would you like more information on how to get and use it?"

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